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THE LUXE FEEL

Bvlgari opened its first store in India at DLF Emporio mall in New Delhi in 2014. It is scheduled to open its second store in Mumbai next year

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ODE TO INDIA

Bvlgari launched its interpretation of the traditional mangalsutra in India in 2021 to woo the Indian market

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appeal to women and then if additionally we can be relevant to men, we are happy to be so," says Babin, who was previously the CEO for 13 years at TAG Heuer, another LVMH brand. In watches, 75 per cent of the business comes from ladies' watches and the balance from men's.

At the recently held Geneva Watch Days, Bvlgari launched a series of new, sparkling watches under both the Octo—known for its ultra-thin timepieces—and the Serpenti collections. It launched the Octo Finissimo Chronograph GMT in rose gold (popular with the Chinese), and the Octo Finissimo Automatic in both rose and yellow gold. Babin expects the yellow gold watch to do well in India. The Serpenti was launched in black ceramic and with diamonds and black spinel as well. While currently at Ethos, the Bvlgari watches for women sell more than men's watches (approximately 60:40), Saboo says there is an increasing demand for the Octo collection and he will not be surprised if men's watches surpass

women's timepieces in a few years.

As the world recovers from the pandemic, Babin says e-commerce has become important. "We took advantage of Covid-19 to increase our e-commerce presence from six countries to 19. So, today most major markets are covered with e-commerce," he says. While India doesn't have an e-commerce site yet, it is in the works. "In India, you have multiple big cities and you cannot pretend to have stores everywhere. In China, there are 100 big cities and we are only in 24. In India you probably have 60 big cities and we will be in 10, so obviously you need e-commerce to complement the accessibility to the brand," he adds. Babin says that while fragrances and leather goods sell on e-commerce sites, for watches and jewellery one needs omnichannel distribution.

Agrees Saboo: "For luxury purchases, customers can browse the products online and then we encourage them to visit the boutique for a touch and feel before purchasing. For regular clients, we send the

watches home, if required."

While LVMH does not provide details of revenues per brand, the company recorded revenue of €36.7 billion in the first half of 2022, up 28 per cent YoY. In the first quarter of 2022, the Watches & Jewelry business group recorded organic revenue growth of 16 per cent YoY. As per a company report, "At Bvlgari, the Serpenti and B.zero1 Classic lines were important growth drivers, while new records were set by the recently launched High Jewelry and High Watchmaking collection *Eden: The Garden of Wonders* and its watch lines, including the new Octo Finissimo Ultra watch."

The affair between Hollywood stars Richard Burton and Elizabeth Taylor resulted in him buying her several pieces from Bvlgari. He quipped: "I introduced Liz to beer and she introduced me to Bvlgari." The Italian *maison* is looking at having a similar love affair with India. **BT**

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